

ON THE ORIGIN OF SPECIES

CHAPTER IV – NATURAL SELECTION

How will the struggle for existence act in regard to variation? Can the principle of selection, which we have seen is so potent in the hands of man, apply under nature? I think we shall see that it can act most effectually.

Owing to this struggle for life, any variation, however slight and from whatever cause proceeding, if it be in any degree profitable to an individual of any species, will tend to the preservation of that individual, and will generally be inherited by its offspring.

This preservation of favourable variations and the rejection of injurious variations, I call Natural Selection.

Editor's summary for the qualification fixture: Darwin developed the theory of natural selection. The mechanism of inheritance causes the survival of favoured individuals. The species derives its characters from variation. The biologist uses the fossil record as evidence.

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